of Statistics and Programme Implementation, Government of India, 2019), p. 100. Research inputs by Rajesh Sharma.

To put this in context, the presence of important women leaders in Delhi is not new in itself. India has had influential women ministers since Nehru's first cabinet included Rajkumari Amrit Kaur. There have been powerful women leaders like Indira Gandhi at the national level and several regional female leaders like AIADMK's late Jayalalithaa, Trinamool's Mamata Banerjee and BJP's Vasundhara Raje. However, the ratio of women ministers overall in successive Union governments was always low (see Figure 17.9).

Thirdly, under Modi and Shah, the BJP instituted important course-corrections on the representation of women in the party's central organisation. These leadership changes ensured for the BJP the highest proportion of women among national office-bearers in India when compared with other major outfits that had 'national party' status. The BJP had as many as 16.9 per cent women as central officer-bearers in October 2020. This was more than women's representation in the central leadership of the CPI(M) (14.7 per cent), Trinamool Congress (13 per cent), CPI (11.1 per cent), NCP (10.8 per cent) and Congress (8.5 per cent). Numbers, of course, tell only half the story. The nature and seniority of the positions these women held was equally important. It is instructive that, when BJP President J.P. Nadda announced his new central leadership team in September 2020, as many as five of his twelve party vice presidents —a whopping 41 per cent—were women.

The social background of these new women vice-presidents is also indicative of the party's changing growth strategy. Apart from the veteran Vasundhara Raje, there was Rita Verma, a Kurmi (OBC) leader and two-time MP from UP who had defeated the former Congress minister Jitin Prasada in the Lok Sabha polls. Verma represented the party's new caste coalition in India's most populous state.[79] Dr Bharti-ben Shiyal, a two-time MP from Bhavnagar and among six women BJP MPs from Gujarat, personified both the party's traditional power base and its bet on younger leadership.[80] Annapurna Devi, a former minister in Manmohan Singh's UPA government and previously head of Lalu Yadav's RJD in Jharkhand,